



Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam - 2025-2026

(De)Constructing Heritage in Architecture and Town Planning

Course Code	L_KBMAERF006
Credits	6
Period	P1
Course Level	400
Language Of Tuition	English
Faculty	Faculty of Humanities
Course Coordinator	prof. dr. F.H. Schmidt
Examiner	prof. dr. F.H. Schmidt
Teaching Staff	prof. dr. F.H. Schmidt, drs. C. Smid
Teaching method(s)	Seminar, Excursion

Course Objective

After following this course, the aim is that you as a student:

1. Understand the historiography and interdisciplinarity of the heritage concept in relationship to the built and urban environment;
2. Are able to apply these understandings to a self-chosen, contemporary restoration or re-use case study;
3. Can critically assess various approaches to material aspects of heritage, in such a way that you are able to produce arguments for and against contemporary interventions in heritage environments;
4. Become aware of your own role as an architectural historian and/or a heritage academic to debates in society, in such a way that you are able to contribute critically and constructively to events and debates.
5. Be able to present and exchange ideas with your fellow students with other disciplinary backgrounds on restoration and re-use cases;
6. Become more self-directed in your approach to your studies, in such a way that you are aware of your specific interests and motivated to let these guide you through this master course.

Course Content

This is one of the introductory courses of the Master Architecture, Cities, Landscapes: History and Heritage (ACL). In this course we critically examine central concepts such as architecture, history, heritage, monument, identity, adaptive reuse and spatial transformation. As the group of students is as interdisciplinary as the academic field of ACL in which we operate, we will analyze and discuss these concepts based on literature that reflects shifts of thought in the field. We will also question and apply them in lectures and individual presentations. In order to get acquainted with current developments in history and heritage concerning the designed and built environment, we will make excursions and welcome guest speakers. Also, you will individually visit related public events and report about them. A final written exam (take-home) will wrap up the course's learning and challenges you to critically assess the understandings and insights you have acquired.

Additional Information Teaching Methods

Lectures, seminars and excursions

Method of Assessment

Individual assignment, weight: 10%, learning goals: 1, 4,
Excursions: preparation and participation, weight: 10%, learning goals: 2, 3, 5,
Group presentation, weight: 30%, learning goals: 1, 2, 3, 5,
Take-home exam, weight: 50%, learning goals: 1, 3, 6.
Final Attainment Levels (eindtermen): 1, 3, 4, 9, 10, 12, 14

Literature

To be announced on Canvas.

Additional Information Target Audience

Master students ACL (compulsory)

Recommended background knowledge

Given the bilingual nature of the master's programme, group meetings will be conducted in English, while individual assignments and tests may be completed in either Dutch or English.